



How To Set Up A 'Professional Looking' E-mail Service

With basic knowledge of DNS and how it works, it is actually possible to set up a free e-mail account and get your mails delivered as if it was from a professionally managed server. Here's how:

1 First, set up an e-mail account with any free e-mail server, say, yourname@rediffmail.com. Or if you have bought an internet connection from you ISP, you can use the e-mail account of your ISP (yourname@vsnl.net, etc.)

2 Set up your own Web site, in one of many free hosting services

3 Buy your own domain name (www.mycompany.com). Indicative prices are given below.

4 If the provider you bought your domain from supports DNS (refer to box: DNSing in the dark), configure it to point to your Web site already hosted in the hosting service. Else, use a free DNS service such as ZoneEdit (www.zoneedit.com) or no-IP (www.no-ip.com)

5 Using ZoneEdit as the example, in the control panel, enter the name of the e-mail account you need to have as an official e-

mail account, viz., mail@mycompany.com, and use ZoneEdit's redirection service to redirect all mail sent to this address to your free account (yourname@rediffmail.com or yourname@vsnl.net, etc.)

6 You can use Outlook, Outlook Express or Netscape mail to send mail. Just use the outgoing mail server name such as smtp.vsnl.net as your outgoing mail server. If you have a leased line or ISDN at office, it is easier to send and receive the 10 MB attachments that can be

sent from most e-mail accounts these days

7 Any e-mail your business associates will receive from your free account will appear to come from mail@mycompany.com, thus imparting a professional look to your business

Location	Company name	Website name	Prices/Year	
			US\$	INR
US	NameSecure	http://www.namesecure.com/en_US/index.jhtml?cat=null&subCat=null	74.90 for 10 years	3,445
India	WebLinkIndia	http://www.weblinkindia.net/web-hosting/index.htm		445
US	GoDaddy	http://www.godaddy.com/gdshop/default.asp	8.95	412
India	Net4Domains	http://www.net4domains.com/	11	500

hundred rupees apiece as the business grows. There are other perks such as sending SMS messages from the mail account and also a large address book that holds 2,500 entries. All this comes for a little under Rs 1,500.

Yahoo!, on the other hand, provides only 25 MB storage per account, and all the facilities that Rediff provides. Other than that, they offer 200 blocked Bayesses, 50 filters and Yahoo!'s trademarked Bayesian spam filters. Additionally, they have waived the \$25 setup fee that they usually charge for new accounts. That brings the cost down to around \$9.95, or around Rs 460.

Indiatimes Meramail features Personalised e-mail IDs, 6 e-mail addresses, 1,200 MB e-mail and 6 GB briefcase space, for a little under Rs 1,500.

All this comes at a price that most businesses can well afford!

However, all this has a sizable downside. As Abbas says, the problem with services such as Rediff, Yahoo! or Indiatimes is that their setup is rather rigid. For starters, Web sites hosted on their servers have problems with language and platform support. They mostly run on Microsoft products, so they generally lack support for PHP or MySQL. This makes Web site maintenance cumbersome, and the number of choices drops significantly. On the other hand, if only the e-



We are not aware of outsourcing options, especially to bigger service providers such as Yahoo! or Rediff. However, free mailboxes are out of question in our line of business; security is important to us.

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mail service is subscribed to, the cost is slightly on the high side. Sharma says that bandwidth for outsourced e-mail management is a definite issue, so is spam. Neither Yahoo! nor Rediff were available for comment.

Yahoo!'s Web hosting and Business Mail solutions are controlled from the US, according to Yahoo! India. That necessarily means the payment has to be made in US dollars and the customer support is also undertaken by US offices. These are issues that would concern an entrepreneur looking to outsource e-mail needs.

On The Other Hand

It is in fact possible to get the same functionality at even lower prices if you have your own business and can spare some time to learn a little bit about Domain Name Servers (DNS). It is possible to actually use your free e-mail account to receive mails sent at your official e-mail id (See box above, "How to Set Up Professional Looking e-mail IDs"). All you need is a little tweaking, and you can bind your e-mail with your domain name and make it look like it is coming from the company mail server.

Setting up a system of this sort means that a lot of the traffic is dependent on free services such as NoIP or ZoneEdit. Which means you are at the mercy of the vagaries of the Internet economy.

Solutions to Swim In!

Most SMEs however, go in for an in-house server for internal e-mail and an outsourced service for external ones. Setting up mail servers, setting up mailboxes, calling up people to ask them to set up your mailboxes for you, it is hard not to be bewildered by so much choice. This is easily managed by keeping in mind the end-point of investing the time and the money. It is ultimately based on the kind of requirement that confronts the company. Choices are choices, but they can only become solutions if chosen judiciously. ■

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DNSing in the dark

Names such as "ThinkDigit.com" are easy for people to remember, but computers do not understand them. They use names called IP addresses to refer to one another instead. For instance, you may type in 'www.thinkdigit.com' into your browser, but your computer connects to '130.94.75.250'. Every time a domain name is used, your computer accesses the domain name servers (DNS) on the Internet to translate the 'domain name' into the machine-readable IP address. During a single day of browsing and e-mailing, your computer might access the domain name servers hundreds of times.